INDIAN OCEAN RIM ASSOCIATION FOR REGIONAL COOPERATION (IOR-ARC)/INDIAN OCEAN RIM ASSOCIATION (IORA)

Mauritius Government sought to enhance economic co-operation among countries of the Indian Ocean Rim. Therefore, it convened a meeting in March 1995 which was attended by representatives from the government, business sectors and academia, from Australia, India, Kenya, Mauritius, Sultanate of Oman, Singapore and South Africa, known as the “Core Group States” or M-7. What emerged out of this meeting was a joint statement with a vision to practice ***Principles of Open Regionalism and Inclusivity of Membership, with the objectives of Trade Liberalization and Promoting Trade Co-operation. Activities would focus on Trade Facilitation, Investment Promotion and Economic Co-operation***. The IOR-ARC was formally launched at the first Ministerial Meeting in Mauritius on 6–7 March 1997. This meeting adopted the IOR-ARC Charter, and determined a number of administrative and procedural matters.

All Sovereign States of the Indian Ocean Rim are eligible for membership. To become members, States must adhere to the principles and objectives enshrined in the Charter. Member states can decide on the expansion of membership of the association. The member countries of IOR-ARC are Australia, Bangladesh, India, Indonesia, Iran, Kenya, Madagascar, Malaysia, Mauritius, Mozambique, Oman, Singapore, South Africa, Sri Lanka, Tanzania, Thailand, the United Arab Emirates, and Yemen. The Seychelles announced its withdrawal from the Association in July 2003, but rejoined in November 2011 taking the membership to 19. The Dialogue Partners are China, Egypt, France, Japan, United Kingdom. The IOR-ARC Observers are currently limited to the Indian Ocean Tourism Organization (IOTO) and the Indian Ocean Research Group (IORG).

IOR-ARC activities include several on-going projects and work programmes conducted by member countries with shared interests, all of which are under the umbrella of three separate working groups. These are the Working Group on Trade and Investment (WGTI), the